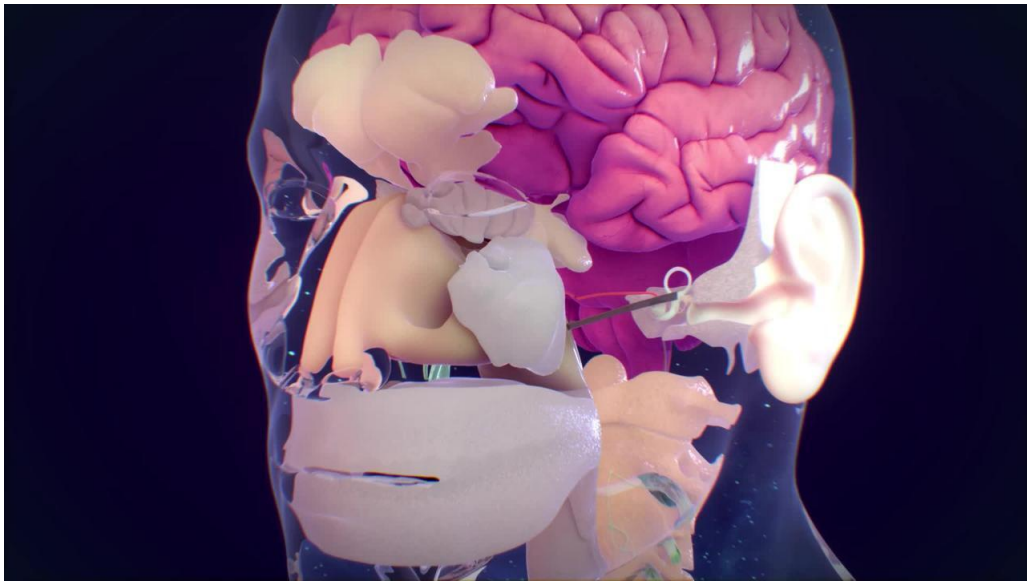






Nosebleeds

(Epistaxis)

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Nose bleeding can range from a trickle to a strong flow, and the consequences can range from a minor annoyance to life-threatening hemorrhage.

Some people get nosebleeds rather often, and others rarely get them. If people swallow the blood, they often vomit it because blood is irritating to the stomach. Swallowed blood may pass through the digestive tract and appear in the stool as black tarry stools.

Anterior nosebleed

Nosebleeds usually come from the front part of the nose (anterior nosebleed). The bleeding comes from small blood vessels in the cartilage that separates the two nostrils (called the nasal septum). The nasal septum contains many blood vessels, and bleeding from this site may result in a lot of blood. Thus, most anterior nosebleeds can be more frightening than serious.

Posterior nosebleed

Bleeding from blood vessels in the back part of the nose (posterior nosebleed), although uncommon, is more dangerous and difficult to treat. Posterior nosebleeds usually involve larger blood vessels than anterior nosebleeds. Because these vessels are in the back of the nose, they are hard for doctors to reach for treatment.

Posterior nosebleeds tend to occur in people who

- Have atherosclerosis (which reduces or blocks blood flow in arteries)
- Have bleeding disorders

Causes of Nosebleeds

Nosebleeds occur when the moist inner lining of the nose is irritated or when blood vessels in the nose are broken. There are many causes of nosebleeds. Regardless of the cause, people who take aspirin or other medications that interfere with blood clotting (anticoagulants), who have a clotting disorder, or who have hardening of the arteries (arteriosclerosis) are more likely to develop nosebleeds.

Common causes

The most common causes of nosebleeds are

- Trauma (such as nose blowing and picking)
- Drying of the moist inner lining of the nose (as occurs in winter)

Less common causes

Less common causes of nosebleeds include

- Nasal infections
- Illicit drug use
- Foreign objects
- Hereditary hemorrhagic telangiectasia
- Tumors of the nose or sinuses

- Bleeding disorders (coagulopathies)
- Bodywide (systemic) disorders

High blood pressure (hypertension) is unlikely to cause a nosebleed, but in people with high blood pressure, the nosebleed may last longer than expected.



- Are taking medications that interfere with blood clotting
- Have had nasal or sinus surgery

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Some Causes and Features of Nosebleeds

Cause*	Common Features† and Tests
Common	
Blowing or picking the nose A blow or other injury to the nose	Typically evident during a doctor's evaluation
Drying of the moist membranes lining the nose, as may occur in cold weather	Usually dryness that is seen during the examination
Less common	
<u>Arteriosclerosis</u>	Usually in older adults
<u>Bleeding disorders</u> (coagulopathies)	In people who have had nosebleeds or other bleeding in other areas, such as the gums Blood tests, such as a complete blood cell count and tests to measure how quickly blood clots
A <u>foreign object</u> (body) in the nose, mainly in children	Often recurring nosebleeds and/or a foul-smelling discharge from one nostril
Illicit drug use (especially <u>cocaine</u>) causing a <u>hole (perforation) in the nasal septum</u> (which divides the interior of the nose in two)	A hole that can be seen during the examination Sometimes in people who snort <u>cocaine</u> frequently
 <u>Nasal infections (such as a <u>cold</u> or <u>sinusitis</u>)</u> reserved.	Nasal discharge, sometimes thick or discolored, and crusting in the nostrils Often irritation of the moist membranes lining the nose
<u>Hereditary hemorrhagic telangiectasia</u> (Osler-Weber-Rendu syndrome)	Dilated small blood vessels (telangiectasias) on the face, lips, membranes lining the mouth and



Nasal infections (such as a cold or sinusitis) reserved.

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